

Thematic reversals in stative non-passives*

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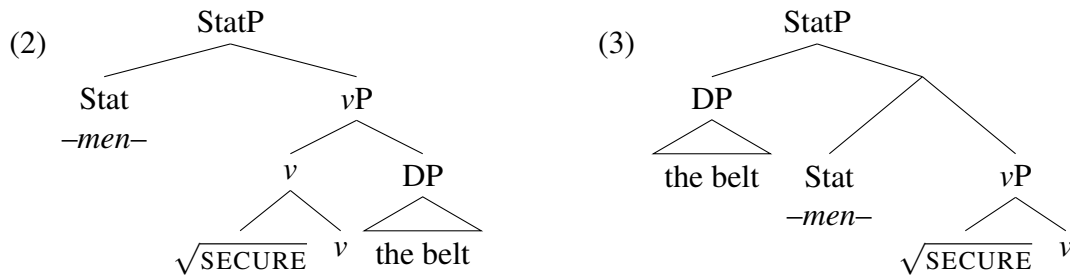
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1. Introduction

Stative passive participles are both stative and event-entailing: the Greek participle formed with the stativizer *–men–* in (1), for instance, describes a set of states, predicated of *the belt*, resulting from a fastening event (see a.o. Markantonatou et al. 1996, Anagnostopoulou 2003, Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou 2008, Alexiadou et al. 2015, Paparounas 2023b).

- (1) I zoni ine iði asfal- iz- men- i.
the.NOM belt.NOM be.3SG already secure VBZ PTCP F.NOM.SG
‘The seat belt is already fastened.’ (stative passive)

A first empirical question on (1) concerns how the nominal *the belt* is introduced; call this the ORIGIN QUESTION. *Low Origin* approaches to this question place the argument in the same position as direct objects of VPs elsewhere.¹ A conceivable alternative holds that the argument originates externally to the verbal projection: this is the *External Predication* view in (3), where the argument is introduced by the stative projection for concreteness.



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¹Low Origin is assumed in much syntactically-oriented work on Greek since Anagnostopoulou (2003) (cf. e.g. Embick 2004 on English). External predication has been recently advocated for different English statives (Embick 2023, Biggs and Embick 2025, Biggs 2021, Fruehwald and Myler 2015); it is also the default option in much lexicalist work (e.g. Levin and Rappaport 1986, McIntyre 2013, Meltzer-Asscher 2011, 2012).

The ORIGIN QUESTION forms part of the broader problem of circumscribing the range of arguments that can appear in the stative passive; call this the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION. Stative passives cannot be predicated of merely any argument. Ditransitive-forming Roots (4a) yield stative passives that, once predicated of a DP, cause that DP to be interpreted as the theme (4b), not the goal, (4c) ((4c) only has a customer-as-theme-of-selling reading). Similarly, agents can never be externalized in the stative passive (5c).

- (4) a. Pulisa tu pelati mia tileorasi.
 sell.PST.1SG the.GEN customer.GEN one.ACC television.ACC
 ‘I sold the customer a television.’
 b. I tileorasi ine pleon pulimeni.
 the.NOM television.NOM be.3SG as.of.now sell.PTCP.F.NOM.SG
 ‘The television is now sold.’
 c. #O pelatis ine pleon pulimenos.
 the.NOM customer.NOM be.3SG as.of.now sell.PTCP.M.NOM.SG
 ‘The customer is now sold.’
- (5) a. O Janis epsise (to kotopulo).
 the.NOM John.NOM roast.PST.3SG the.ACC chicken.ACC
 ‘John roasted (the chicken).’
 b. To kotopulo ine pleon psimeno.
 the.NOM chicken.NOM be.3SG as.of.now roast.PTCP.N.NOM.SG
 ‘The chicken is now roasted.’
 c. #O Janis ine pleon psimenos.
 the.NOM John.NOM be.3SG as.of.now roast.PTCP.M.NOM.SG
 ‘John is now roasted.’

The task is thus to specify not only where arguments are introduced, as in (2) to (3), but also why these arguments must bear specific interpretations. Theories of stative passive formation have accordingly constrained the formation of stative passives such that it makes reference either to the thematic role Theme (Williams 1981, Bresnan 1982) or to the notion *direct argument* of the predicate (Levin and Rappaport 1986) or of the Root (Embick 2004). Important differences between these strategies notwithstanding,² they both begin from the assumption that the DPs appearing in stative passives share some well-defined property, thematic or positional.

This paper tackles two cases that appear to constitute exceptions to this uniform pattern, in Greek and in English. The relevant cases seem to involve, *prima facie*, the DP appearing in the stative passive being interpreted as the *agent* of the entailed event; this being the opposite of the typical situation in (1)-(5), I dub such cases *thematic reversals*.

The paper’s main claim is that a novel observation on the distribution of thematic reversals is crucially probative as to the ORIGIN QUESTION. In particular, the fact that thematic

²Levin and Rappaport (1986) forgoes reference to the role Theme based largely on assumptions on the behavior of *feed*-type verbs that are not current; see Anagnostopoulou 2001 for a pertinent case study, and see also Dubinsky and Simango (1996) on Levin and Rappaport (1986).

reversals take place in stative passives, but never in their eventive counterparts, shows that the label ‘stative passive’ is a misnomer: the DP of which Greek stative passives are predicated is introduced externally to the verbal core, per (3), and its core semantic integration is only with the stative eventuality, not the event. Pursuing the details of how such effects arise in turn provides insights into the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION.

Before proceeding, it is important to establish that the generalizations making up the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION cannot be stated at the level of the Root; that is, it is not the case that some Roots can appear in the stative passive, while others cannot. Consider to this end two prototypical unergative-forming Roots in Greek, $\sqrt{\text{LAUGH}}$ and $\sqrt{\text{RUN}}$. As in English, $\sqrt{\text{LAUGH}}$ is canonically obligatorily intransitive: adding an internal argument is normally impossible (6a). Interestingly, transitive (really, object experiencer) *laugh* becomes possible under clitic doubling (6b), in which case a special interpretation of the Root is triggered: (6b) describes John being conned or deceived, and in this interpretation only, the verb may appear with the prefix *kse-*; for the role of clitic doubling in similar experiencer constructions, see e.g. Anagnostopoulou (1999), Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou (2019). Crucially, stative passives formed from $\sqrt{\text{LAUGH}}$ are perfectly possible, but only under the transitive construal: (6c) can describe states held by John resulting from a deceiving event he sustained, but not from a laughing event. (7) illustrates the same state of affairs for $\sqrt{\text{RUN}}$; (for some speakers the interpretation ‘to put someone through the wringer’ is only available under prefixation with the intensifier *kata-*, in which case the verb has a stronger connotation of hounding or harassing).

- (6) a. Ta peđja jelasan (*ton Jani).
the.NOM.PL child.NOM.PL laugh.PST.3PL the.ACC John.ACC
‘The children laughed (John).’
- b. Ta peđja *(ton) (kse-) jelasan ton Jani.
the child.NOM.PL 3SG.M.ACC PRFX laugh.PST.3PL the John.ACC
‘The children deceived John.’
- c. O Janis apođixθike (kse-) jelazmenos.
the.NOM John.NOM prove.NACT.PST.3SG PRFX laugh.PTCP.M.NOM
✓‘John proved to be deceived.’ ✗‘John proved to be laughed.’
- (7) a. To afendiko treçi (*ton Jani).
the.NOM boss.NOM run.3SG the.ACC John.ACC
‘The boss runs (John).’
- b. To afendiko *(ton) %(kata-) treçi ton Jani.
the.NOM boss.NOM 3SG.M.ACC PRFX run.3SG the.ACC John.ACC
‘The boss puts John through the wringer/hounds John.’
- c. O Janis mu fenete %(kata-) treymenos.
the.NOM John.NOM 3SG.M.GEN appear.3SG PRFX run.PTCP.M.NOM
✓‘John seems to me to be hounded.’ ✗‘John seems to me to be run.’

The moral from (6)-(7) is clear. There is no blanket restriction against Roots like $\sqrt{\text{LAUGH}}$ and $\sqrt{\text{RUN}}$ appearing in stative passives; they do, but only with interpretations that suggest

that these Roots have entered a functional structure involving a Theme. From the point of view of the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION, (6)-(7) then reinforce the conclusion that this question must be tackled via reference to either thematic roles or syntactic positions, but not at the level of Roots wholesale.

2. Thematic reversals: Ingestives

2.1 The pattern

Recall from above that arguments appearing in stative passives are canonically read as themes of the entailed event, and that this generalization has been captured either via reference to this thematic role itself, or to the notion *direct argument*.

Statives of ingestive verbs constitute an exception to this generalization (see esp. Anagnostopoulou 2001, Arad 1998; cf. e.g. Haspelmath 1994:161, Naess 2011:418ff).³ The basic pattern can be illustrated with reference to $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$. Stative passives formed from this Root can license the expected interpretation of their sole argument, whereby this element is read as the theme of the associated event; (8) illustrates. But stative passives formed on the basis of $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$ license a second, exceptional interpretation, one where the sole argument seems to be understood as the *agent* of the corresponding event. Thus, the Greek counterpart of *Mary is eaten* is felicitous not just in contexts like the one in (8), but also in situations where Mary is understood to have done the eating: (9) illustrates by showing that the stative passive (A1) and the active perfect (A2) of *eat* are equally acceptable ways of asserting that Mary is done eating.

(8) [The vicious human-eating plant consumes Mary.]

I Maria ine pleon faɣo- men- i.
the.NOM Mary.NOM be.3SG as.of.now eat PTCP F.NOM
'Mary is now eaten.'

(9) a. Q: I'm setting the table – is Mary joining us?

b. A1: Oçi, i Maria ine faɣo- men- i.
no the.NOM Mary.NOM be.3SG eat PTCP F.NOM
'No – Mary has eaten.' (stative passive)

c. A2: Oçi, i Maria eçi fai.
no the.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG eat.PFV
'No – Mary has eaten.' (active perfect)

³The patterns discussed are part of a broader cross-linguistic picture on the properties of the argument structure of ingestive verbs; see e.g. Saksena 1980, Newman 2009, Krejci 2012, Bhatt and Embick 2017, Smith et al. 2024. Ingestive verbs behave in a special way with respect to both stativization and (a type of) causativization: see e.g. Greek in Anagnostopoulou (2001); Hindi in Saksena 1980, Bhatt and Embick 2017; Chichewa in Baker 1988:461. I leave the intriguing links here for future work.

The full set of Roots licensing this exceptional possibility in Greek is shown in (10) (Anagnostopoulou 2001). This state of affairs is representative of the broader crosslinguistic picture: the exact set of Roots licensing thematic reversals varies from language to language, but the relevant Roots are always ingestive, literally or metaphorically (see references cited above).

- (10) I Maria ine { fayο- , pço- , ðiavaz- , maθi- } men- i.
the Mary.NOM be.3SG $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$ $\sqrt{\text{DRINK}}$ $\sqrt{\text{STUDY}}$ $\sqrt{\text{LEARN}}$ PTCP F.NOM

It bears emphasizing that the thematic reversal is not enabled by context alone. (11) illustrates that a non-ingestive Root like $\sqrt{\text{PAY}}$ cannot license the special interpretation even in a context where this would be highly plausible – any other non-ingestive Root would serve to make the same point.

- (11) [*Splitting the check, our group discovers that Mary has already paid for her bit.*]
a. Q: Does Mary need to put her card down?
b. A1: #Oçi, i Maria ine pliro- men- i.
no the.NOM Mary.NOM be.3SG pay PTCP F.NOM
Intended: ‘No – Mary has paid.’
c. A2: Oçi, i Maria eçi plirosi.
no the.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG pay.PFV
‘No – Mary has paid.’

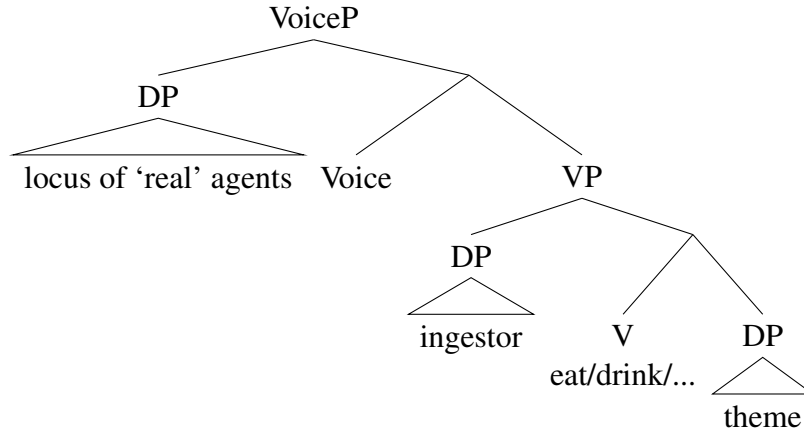
2.2 The basic analysis

At first glance, thematic reversals with ingestives are probative at most as to the argument structure of ingestive verbs, but not as to the structure of the stative passive. The intuition along these lines would be as follows. The external argument of ingestive verbs – call it the ingestor for convenience – is sometimes described as an *affected agent* (e.g. Haspelmath 1994:161ff; Saksena 1980; Naess 2011; Newman 2009): in prototypical ingestive events, ingestion alters the (physical or mental) composition of the ingestor. The intuition in the typological literature on ingestives is thus that their agents may be notionally more ‘patient-like’ than those of other predicates. Perhaps, then, all that (9b) reflects is a quirk of ingestive verbs: they allow ingestors to be just theme-like enough to participate in stative passive formation (NB also footnote 3: ingestives behave in interesting ways beyond statives).

The approach in Anagnostopoulou 2001, the most thorough theoretical discussion of ingestives to date, can be seen as embodying this broad intuition in structural terms. Anagnostopoulou proposes that ingestives enter a structure involving an intermediate, VP-internal argument, one that can be interpreted as an agent whenever the ‘real’ agent DP is missing (a ‘dependent role’ approach). Though the details of how this structure enters stative passives is not the primary focus of Anagnostopoulou (2001), a plausible account based on (12) would state that the ingestor is theme-like enough thematically, and/or low enough structurally, to be targeted for inclusion in the stative passive; and that, since agents are

excluded from the stative passive, this argument comes to be interpreted as an agent per the dependent role mechanism.

(12)



The intuition that ingestors are notionally theme-like, and the specific structural implementation beginning from (12), both constitute crucial insights. But a novel observation reveals that neither is sufficient to account for the full range of facts: thematic reversals arise only in the stative passive, and never in the eventive passive. (13) illustrates for three Greek ingestives: their eventive passives only license readings where Mary is the theme of events of ingestion, as the more felicitous (13b) further clarifies. The other Greek ingestive Roots, as well as ingestives in Italian (Andrea Beltrama, p.c.) and Hebrew (Noa Nikolsky, p.c.), behave identically.

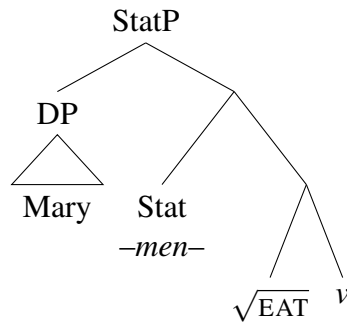
- (13) a. #I Maria eçi { façoθi / ðjavasti /
 the.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG eat.PFV.3SG read.PFV.3SG
 maθefti }.
 learn.PFV.3SG
 Only reading: 'Mary was eaten/read/learned.'
- b. To psomi eçi façoθi / to vivlio eçi
 the.NOM bread.NOM have.3SG eat.PFV.3SG the.NOM book.NOM have.3SG
 ðjavasti / to mistiko eçi maθefti.
 read.PFV.3SG the.NOM secret.NOM have.3SG learn.PFV.3SG
 'The bread has been eaten / the book has been read / the secret has been found out.'

The distribution of thematic reversals is thus asymmetrical: they target the stative passive specifically. The phenomenon thus cannot be merely about the properties of ingestive verbs: if (9b) reflected merely a special way of understanding what the role Theme means in the context of an ingestive Root, then this effect should arise in the eventive passive (13a) unproblematically. Similarly, if the thematic reversal were driven solely by the fact that

ingestors are merged lower than canonical external arguments, it would be unclear why these specially introduced arguments behave differently in stative and eventive passives.⁴

I thus propose that thematic reversals demand a particular view of the syntactic introduction and thematic integration of arguments in the stative passive. Since thematic reversals arise specifically in stative passives, we have to ‘know’ that the structure is stative before introducing the exceptionally interpreted argument. Only if stative passives are instances of external predication (15) can we correctly circumscribe the thematic reversal to the stative passive.

(14)



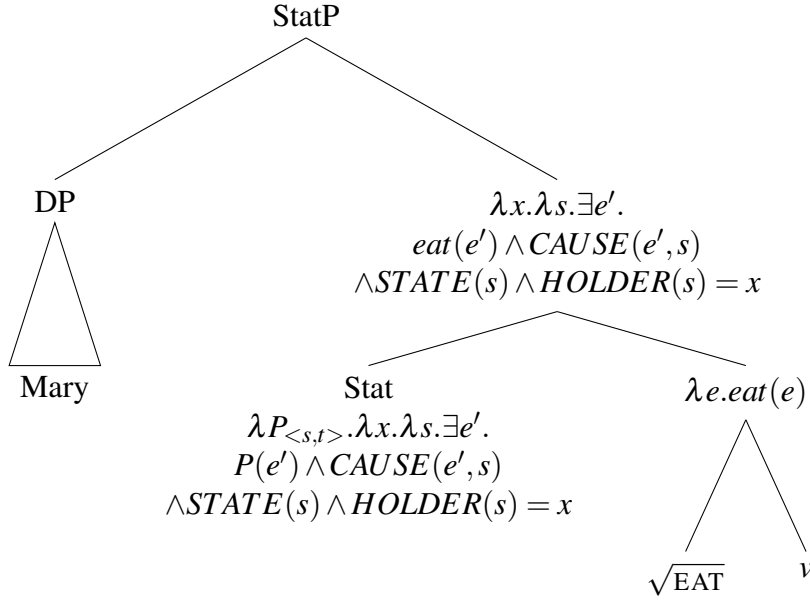
More specifically, I propose that thematic reversals arise only in the stative because only in the stative is it the case that the argument *Mary* is structurally severed from the verbal projection, per (14). Note that the constituent structure here is supported quite independently of thematic reversals, from data from idioms (see Paparounas 2023b:ch. 4; Paparounas 2023a).

Importantly, this structural difference between eventives and statives correlates with an interpretive difference. In (15), the eventuality to which *Mary* is directly linked is the state, by means of a holder role; this argument is not linked to the event, at least not directly.

⁴Elena Anagnostopoulou (p.c.) conjectures that the impossibility of (13a) arises, on a view like (12), from a treatment of the ingestor as a non-canonical external argument on a par with those of Greek deponent and subject experiencer verbs (see e.g. Grestenberger 2018, Zombolou and Alexiadou 2014), which similarly resist eventive passivization. This account would need to specify, given (12), what guarantees that the ‘wrong’ argument (i.e. the ingestor) can be externalized in the stative passive. Note also that, importantly, thematic reversals do not obtain with deponents (i) and subject experiencer verbs (ii).

- (i) I Maria ine katara- men- i.
the.NOM Mary.NOM be.3SG curse PTCP F.NOM
‘Mary is cursed’; NOT ‘Mary has cursed (someone)’
- (ii) a. To sçeđio ine skarfiz- men- o.
the.NOM plan.NOM be.3SG think.up PTCP N.NOM
‘The plan is devised.’
b. #O efevretis ine skarfiz- men- os.
the.NOM inventor.NOM be.3SG think.up PTCP M.NOM
Intended: ‘The inventor has come up (with something).’

(15)



(15) echoes the conclusions of works on stative passives in other languages insofar as they take the core argument of stative passives to be fully external (see Meltzer-Asscher 2011, 2012, Horvath and Siloni 2008 for Hebrew; McIntyre 2013, Levin and Rappaport 1986 and, to some extent, Bruening 2014 for English). It differs from these works, however, in taking it that the interpretation of this element is also distinguished from the theme of transitives/eventive passives; in this respect it follows most closely the analyses of English *done*-statives in Biggs (2021), Fruehwald and Myler (2015), though some analytical details differ.⁵

Once we countenance the view of thematic interpretation in the stative passive expressed in (15), we have the beginnings of a solution that derives the asymmetry between eventive and stative passives with respect to thematic reversals. Whereas the eventive passive involves an instance of strict thematic determination, with the internal argument associated with the theme role, the stative passive associates the argument in question with the state, affording thematic flexibility, in principle, as to its role in the state-yielding event. As in Kratzer (1996), I take the role of state-holder assigned to some x to be compatible with the inference that x is responsible for the state's obtaining, but also with construals where x is affected by the state in looser ways. The next section offers two ways of making this statement more precise.

2.3 Implementing the reversal: Two options

The claim in the previous section was that the argument of the stative passive is directly integrated only with the stative eventuality. It must be the case, then, that the relation linking the argument to the event arises by inference.

⁵For instance, Biggs (2021) takes the state-holder DP to also control a PRO in the lower agent position.

Note firstly now that the postulation of a holder in (15) does not serve to distinguish this account from alternatives: any account of the interpretation of stative passives must ultimately postulate this role. To see why, consider an important detail of thematic reversals: thematically reversed statives necessarily entail the full completion of the state-yielding event. We thus find the contrast in (16): the state entailed by the active perfect (16a) is fully compatible with a denial of the eating event's having run to completion, in some contextually salient sense; but this is not so for the stative passive, which yields a clear contradiction (16b). In other words, thematically reversed *eaten* means 'full', not merely 'having consumed food'; this effect obtains with all similar formations elsewhere, e.g. English *drunk* and Italian *bevuto* meaning 'inebriated'.

- (16) a. I Maria eçi fai, ala ðen eçi xortasi.
 the.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG eat.PFV but NEG have.3SG become.full.PFV
 'Mary has eaten, but she's not full.'
- b. I Maria ine faço- meni, #ala ðen eçi
 the.NOM Mary.NOM be.1SG $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$ PTCP.F.NOM but NEG have.3SG
 xortasi.
 become.full.PFV
 'Mary is eaten, but she's not full.'

The account in (15) straightforwardly derives (16b): since Mary is directly identified as the holder of a state in which an event has culminated, she must have taken part in the event to completion (see also below). An account that attributes to *Mary* a primary status with respect to the event will have to derive the same result by associating her derivatively with the state. The two accounts thus cannot differ with respect to whether the argument is ultimately linked to the state, but only with respect to whether the argument is primarily a state participant that is associated with the event derivatively, or the inverse (see also Bruening 2014, Meltzer-Asscher 2011 for two External Predication-based analyses that employ abstraction to link the externally introduced nominal to the event). Either way, an inference is necessary.

For regular (non-thematically reversed) statives, the account here must implement this inference along the lines of (17). This meaning postulate, closely related to the *End Theme* postulate of Parsons (1990) (cf. Williams 2015 and Biggs and Embick, this volume), is an instruction to interpret holders of event-entailing states as themes of the entailed events.

- (17) *General meaning postulate for stative passives*
 $[event(e) \wedge CAUSE(e, s) \wedge STATE(s) \wedge HOLDER(s) = x] \models [THEME(e) = x]$
 'Interpret the holder of an event-entailing state as the theme of the entailed event.'

Thematic reversals also have their root in the fact that, in stative passives (of ingestive verbs), the structure does not fully determine the relation between this element and the event; and this indeterminacy affords the kind of flexibility with respect to the argument's

role in the event that gives rise to the thematic reversal. Two views on the source of this effect arise.

According to the first option, thematic reversals arise from an interpretive possibility fully distinct from (17). A second meaning postulate (18), existing alongside (17) and ordered disjunctively with respect to it, would state that, in the context of some set of Roots, state-holders of event-entailing states are read as Agents (Paparounas 2023b:ch. 4).

- (18) *Specific meaning postulate for ingestives*
 $[event(e) \wedge CAUSE(e, s) \wedge STATE(s) \wedge HOLDER(s) = x] \models [AGENT(e) = x]$ in
the context of $\{ \sqrt{EAT}, \sqrt{LEARN}, \dots \}$
‘In the context of $\{ \sqrt{EAT}, \sqrt{LEARN}, \dots \}$, interpret the holder of an event-entailing state as an Agent.’

(18) makes a strong commitment, namely, that the thematic reversal results from the state holder being associated (even if by inference) with the role Agent. This strong position is at least compatible with the observation that entities that do not make for good Agents of eating events conceptually also do not felicitously appear in thematically reversed statives: babies, plants and egos can be felicitously fed in transitives (19a), and they can appear in regular statives of $\sqrt{FEED}$, but not in a thematically reversed $\sqrt{EAT}$ stative.

- (19) a. Taisa to moro / (?)fito / eyo mu.
feed.PST.1SG the.ACC baby.ACC plant.ACC ego.ACC 1SG.GEN
‘I fed the baby/the plant/my ego.’
b. To moro / (?)fito / eyo mu ine pleon {
the.NOM baby.NOM plant.NOM ego.NOM 1SG.GEN be.3SG as.of.now
taismeno / #fayomeno }.
feed.PTCP.N.NOM eat.PTCP.N.NOM
‘The baby/the plant/my ego is now fed/full.’

Although arguably capturing the facts, (18) is unsatisfying. It places on a List elements that arguably form a natural class, namely ingestive Roots; worse yet, it fails to specify why it is only ingestive Roots that license thematic reversals, and treats it as an accident that this behavior recurs cross-linguistically.

These concerns may turn out to favor a move towards a second option, according to which the only rule of interpretation operative for stative passives is the general rule in (17). On this account, the interpretation of the argument of a thematically-reversed stative passive would be the same as that of any other stative, namely Theme; aspects of the lexical semantics of ingestives would then guarantee the thematic reversal through the back door.

Such a view would require ingestive verbs to permit two kinds of end states. As with other Roots, stative passives formed from $\sqrt{EAT}$ would denote states of eatenness; this much would give rise to the expected interpretation (8). The exceptional interpretation in (9b) would then involve a distinct end state, one of fullness, with eating merely representing the means through which this state was attained. This general idea might be encoded in

a more articulated semantic representation such as that of Biggs and Embick (this volume), who approach the interpretation of stative passives through the lens of the *Process Semantics* for resultatives in Williams (2015). Concretely, if complex changes such as those denoted by the stative passive consist of three eventualities (a Process, a Means, and an End State), then $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$ would be associated with the End State in (8), but with the Means in (9b).

That $\sqrt{\text{EAT}}$ might create stative passives with End States that are not states of eatenness may receive support from the examples in (20): an *eaten* sweater is not a sweater that has been entirely consumed, but rather one that is visibly tatty as a result of moth attacks. Relatedly, (20b) denotes a state of erosion. In both cases, literal or metaphorical eating represents the means by which a different state altogether has been attained; perhaps (9b) represents another such case.

- (20) a. To pulover ine (skoro-) fayomeno.
the.NOM sweater.NOM be.3SG moth eat.PTCP.N.NOM
'The sweater is (moth-) eaten.'
- b. O vraxos ine fayomenos eki pu ton
the.NOM rock.NOM be.3SG eat.PTCP.M.NOM there that 3SG.M.ACC
vreçi i θalasa.
wet.3SG the.NOM sea.NOM
'The rock is eaten away at the spot where the sea hits it.'

The details clearly remain to be fleshed out; an important desideratum for an approach maintaining that thematic reversals also involve Themes is to guarantee that the effect is circumscribed to the stative passive, and does not extend to the eventive. Alongside these empirical considerations, the choice between the two options outlined here will likely depend on broader decision points involving the (non-)availability of contextually-sensitive interpretive rules that make reference to particular Roots.

3. Concluding remarks

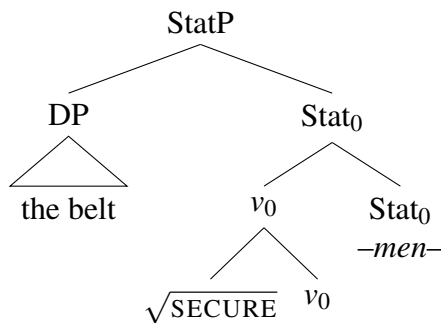
This paper took as its starting point two persistent questions for theories of stative passives: the ORIGIN QUESTION and the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION. The two questions are intimately linked. In particular, I have argued that thematic reversals in Greek stative passives shed new light on the ORIGIN QUESTION, by enabling a new argument in favor of an External Predication analysis of these structures; but that, once we turn to the question of how exactly to implement these effects, new questions arise that are intimately linked to the CIRCUMSCRIPTION QUESTION at large.

By way of conclusion, it is worth emphasizing links between the questions pursued here and broader issues in the domain of syntactic word formation. The focus of this paper has been on the *argument structure* of Greek stative passives; but the conclusions reached here must be viewed against recent discussion of the *event structure* of such constructions. In particular, Paparounas (2023b:ch. 4) argues that the verbal core of the Greek stative passive is not directly accessible by (phrasal) modifiers, such that only state-level modification is

licit; such results have been reported for other languages (see a.m.o. Rapp 1996, Meltzer-Asscher 2011, McIntyre 2013, Biggs and Embick 2025).

Putting these results together, the verbal core of stative passives in Greek hosts neither arguments nor phrasal modifiers (cf. resultatives in Williams 2015:315ff). This state of affairs can be understood on a *complex head* approach to stative passive formation, whereby the complement of the stativizing head Stat cannot be phrasal (see also Embick 2023, Biggs and Embick 2025, Paparounas 2023a and Hamo and Meihami this volume; cf. Wood 2023, Benz 2023, Lee 2024, Epstein et al. 2016, Bruening 2019). An important desideratum for future work is to further elucidate the properties of such structures, and to compare their predictions to those of approaches making use of lexical rules (Embick 2023).

(21) *Complex head*



Finally, the empirical core of this paper, thematic reversals, may be more prevalent than it seems.⁶ The focus here has been on thematic reversals with ingestives, a cross-linguistically common pattern; but similar effects obtain under resultative secondary predication, as briefly mentioned above. One underdiscussed case in English involves resultative *out*–: unergative-forming Roots form flawless stative passives in the presence of *out* (22), suggesting that *out* creates the conditions for the argument of the stative passive to be interpreted (plausibly, as a theme; see Biggs and Embick this volume). Crucially, once again, thematic reversals are impossible in eventive passives (23).

- (22) a. I'm (all) partied #(out).
 b. I'm (all) danced #(out).
 c. I swim lap after lap...until my arms won't stroke and my feet won't kick. That only takes about 45 minutes, and then I'm all swum out.⁷

- (23) a. I was (all) partied out. ✓stative ✗eventive
 b. I was (all) danced out. ✓stative ✗eventive

⁶The apparent reversals discussed in Bresnan (1995:13ff), involving examples like *confessed killer*, are of a different type. They are incompatible with *un*- prefixation (Embick 2004:fn. 6), are impossible in predicative position (Bruening 2014:appendix 2), sometimes have transitive or unaccusative sources, and in any case are less systematic than either the ingestive cases or the English examples with *out*- discussed in the main text.

⁷Attested:<https://tinyurl.com/mtd4vae8>

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